

important question: is India's second line of Test pacers ready?

While Prasad Krishna and Akash Deep have shown glimpses of promise, many believe the fast-bowling unit still lacks depth beyond Bumrah and Siraj. That makes this Ranji season especially crucial.

"Some of the players have done reasonably well in domestic cricket, but it is important that we identify them and judge them based on their talent and not compare them with someone else," says Banerjee. "It is impossible to find a like-for-like player for Bumrah or Siraj, but what should be focused on is whether a fast bowler has the skill one is looking for and whether he can adapt to the grind of red-ball cricket," adds the former quick.

The contenders

Among Indian pacers aged under 30, Akash has been the standout performer in First-Class cricket over the past three years. The 28-year-old tops the sub-group with 109 wickets at an average of 27.44 and has already featured in Tests. Earlier this year, he produced his most eye-catching international performance with a match-winning 10-wicket haul against England at Edgbaston.

The only other Indian pacer under 30 to take 100 or more First-Class wickets since 2022 is Vijaykumar Vyshak. The Karnataka quick impressed in the IPL with his death-overs discipline for Punjab Kings in 2025 and earned his maiden India call-up for the T20I series in South Africa, though he didn't get a game. His State-mate Vidwath Kaverappa, 25, continues to rise with 82 First-Class wickets at an average of 21.50.

Despite an underwhelming Test debut, Anshul Kamboj of Haryana remains one to watch. He first caught attention with a 10-wicket match haul against Kerala in 2024 and impressed again with a fiery 4/34 in the Irani Trophy for Rest of India, albeit in defeat.

Another promising name is Harshit Rana, already capped in all three formats. The 23-year-old's



hit-the-deck aggression has clearly impressed the national management. But the standout pacer of the 2024-25 season was Auqib Nabi from Jammu & Kashmir, who topped the charts with 44 wickets at an astonishing 13.93, helping his team reach its first-ever quarterfinal. He continued that form in the Duleep Trophy, taking four wickets in four balls for North Zone.

Beyond these statistical leaders, selectors are also looking at bowlers who bring distinct physical attributes. Gurnoor Brar, standing 6'3", has been fast-tracked into the India A setup and recently impressed against Australia A with his bounce and movement.

The spin factor

While pacers may headline the conversation, several spinners could also draw attention. Mumbai's Tanush Kotian appears next in line behind Washington Sundar for the off-spinner's role, and his batting adds further value: he averages close to 45, often featuring in lower-order

Left-arm revelation: Harsh Dubey's remarkable 69-wicket haul powered Vidarbha's Ranji run and marked him as one of India's brightest spin prospects. EMMANUAL YOGINI

rescue acts for Mumbai and West Zone. Rajasthan's Manav Suthar, a left-arm spinner long on the selectors' radar, picked 39 wickets in 2022-23 and followed that with 17 the next season. This year, he made a mark with eight wickets in an unofficial Test against Australia A and added five wickets plus an unbeaten 56 for Rest of India in the Irani Cup.

Vidarbha's Harsh Dubey broke the record for most wickets in a single Ranji season last year — 69 at 16.98 — but India's spin department currently looks settled, meaning he and others may have to wait their turn.

The No. 3 conundrum

While India's Test lineup appears largely stable, uncertainty persists over who should occupy the No. 3